

THE GENERAL HUMANITIES

ONE of the most interesting facts in the growth of the Hebrew University is the development in it of the General Humanities. The first "Arts" subject outside Jewish Studies was, appropriately enough, Greek, but Greek was introduced originally not for its own sake but as an adjunct to Biblical study. It was found that the early students in the Institute of Jewish Studies had no Greek and could not therefore read the Septuagint! A preparatory division was immediately set up to teach intending Bible students the rudiments of Greek from which they could go on to read the Greek versions of the Bible.

This preparatory division soon expanded however. In 1928, the first year of regular undergraduate teaching, the "Greek for beginners", with its "Select Readings from the Septuagint and Apocrypha", gave way to regular courses in Greek Language and Literature and Greek and Roman History; and though the Septuagint and Philo were still retained as subjects for special seminar work, they were supplanted for the ordinary student by Homer and Euripides. There is now a fully functioning department of Classics; while a general course of Classical Culture for the newly instituted degree of B. A. attracts some twenty five per cent of the total undergraduate body.

The pioneer subject in *modern* languages was romance philology, taught almost from the first days of the University. Of the major European languages we have now independent departments of English and French. Italian and Spanish are dealt with under the aegis of the Romance Languages, and

there is a modest beginning of an introductory course in Russian. The study of language and literature depends entirely on libraries, and one cannot but record with profound gratitude the gift of the collection of standard books in French made by the French Government (to the munificence of which indeed we owe the founding and maintenance of the French department as a whole) and the admirable working library in English literature presented by the British Council.

After language and literature the standard humanistic disciplines are philosophy and history. In their Jewish aspects these formed part of the original programme of the Institute of Jewish Studies; in their general aspects they have been taught in the University since the beginning of undergraduate studies. The department of Philosophy has covered the ordinary branches of the subject from its opening in 1928. The department of History has evolved gradually; indeed, curiously enough, its development has been chronological, the mediaeval period being added after the classical had been taught for some years, the modern after the mediaeval. To History should be subjoined (as it was originally attached) the subject of International Relations, to Philosophy, that of Psychology, although our psychologists have tended (I think rightly) to drift more in the direction of the observational sciences and speak in terms of laboratories and experiment. With Psychology one naturally associates the allied but independent School of Education in which however the practice of education is emphasised as well as its theoretical principles and history.

The great recent expansion in the General Humanities is in the field of the Social Sciences. The start was made with the somewhat unusual subject of Cultural Sociology which gradually expanded into Sociology as such. Then came Economics and Statistics (with its interesting adjunct Demography), and lastly Political Science.

I say "lastly" only with reference to the date of the last appointment for we have still far to go, but at least we have the ground-work of a possible (even a respectable) *School*, even perhaps eventually a special *Faculty*, of the Social Sciences and Administration. But Administration may go over to the newly established Faculty of Law, and I do not wish to make any prophecies.

At this point we are brought face to face with the central difficulty of organisation: is it really possible to classify subjects so exactly? Is Sociology or even Education a part of the General Humanities; is Psychology; is Political Economy? What is Archaeology? General Humanities, or? — but I do not know what to suggest; what is Prehistory — General Humanities, or? Does Moslem Art come under Art (and if so, to be reckoned under General Humanities) or (as it does now) the Institute of Oriental Studies? What are we to say of Numismatics and Epigraphy? It is obvious that these and many other subjects taught by members of the Faculty have both their general and their special side. Exclusive classification is impossible.

But so, too, is the exclusive study, and we are brought back to my original point. The University has proved in practice that cast-iron divisions of "Institutes" and "Departments", even of "Faculties", are unworkable. Subject overflows into subject, Department into Department, Institute into Institute; and now Faculty is flowing over into Faculty. Students and teachers are becoming amphibious creatures living in two media at once.

But such amphibious life (with all respect to the specialists) is good, good for the teachers, good for the students, good for the institution as a whole. It is only when one has a free interchange of ideas that intellectual progress, or even the plainest intellectual understanding, is possible. Culture depends on cross-fertilisation.

A further point in a similar direction may be noted. We have always fought against the merely utilitarian view of University study and have striven to prevent our language departments, for example, from becoming mere schools of commercial correspondence. Language and Literature are always studied together, and the attempt is made to introduce students through literature to the widest cultural values. On the other hand the University, as far as it can, tries to help students to use languages for professional purposes as well by the maintenance of introductory classes. Whether this is good or not (and a strong case might be made out against it in the abstract), we have been forced to do so in the past and shall probably continue to be forced to do so in the future, and that for the reason which will appear strange to those who only know Jews outside Palestine, that the young Palestinian Jew has very little of that polylingual talent which distinguishes the Jew elsewhere. This brings me to the heart of our problem.

The cultural danger in any small country is that of parochialism. The reasons are many. They may spring from an over-zealous local patriotism, an over-strong sense of personal achievement, a fear of strangers or an imperfect acquaintance with history; but in every case the result is the same: a narrowing of the horizon with a corresponding narrowing of the mind. Our task in this generation is to lay the foundations of a culture which though rooted in the national spirit shall yet grow up into and in the free air of the world at large.

This task is laid in particular upon the General Humanities, and we shall be fortunate indeed if we can begin to carry it out. It is a special duty, difficult but possible, and the master keys are, as they always have been, the three subjects of literature, history and philosophy. The final source of parochialism is ignorance of the best: of the best that has been created in thought, of the best that has been experienced in life, of the best that has been embodied in literature. It is this ignor-

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ance that in the last analysis the study of the Humanities exists to dispel.

Such a dispelling is not only good in itself. It releases the innate creative impulse and opens the way to fresh expression.